

Dichotomy: there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.

Non-universality: some
people go to heaven,
and some to hell.

Divine control: it is up
to God who goes to heaven
and who goes to hell.

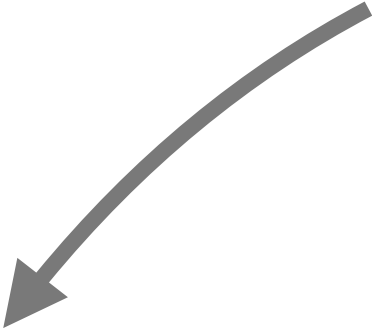
Proportionality: justice is proportional, in the sense that it “prohibits very unequal treatment of persons who are very similar in relevant respects.”

By Non-universality and Divine control, it follows that God decides that some people - call them group A - go to heaven and that some other people - group B - go to hell. By Badness, it follows that group A is much better off than group B. By Dichotomy, it follows that every human being is either in group A or group B. By Proportionality (given that the people in group A are much, much better off than the ones in group B), it follows that if God is just, there must be some way of dividing people into groups A and B which does not place people who are relevantly very similar into different groups. So by Justice, it follows that there must be some way of dividing people into groups A and B which does not place people who are relevantly very similar into different groups.

Justice: God's judgement about who goes to heaven & hell is just.

God sends some people
(group A) to heaven
and everyone else
(group B) to hell.





Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

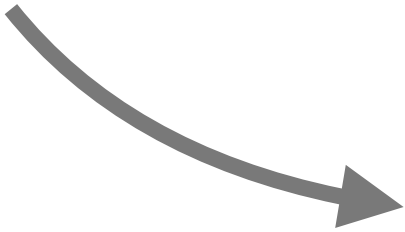
Dichotomy: there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.



Badness: people in hell
are very, very much worse
off than people in
heaven.

God makes group A
much better off
than group B.



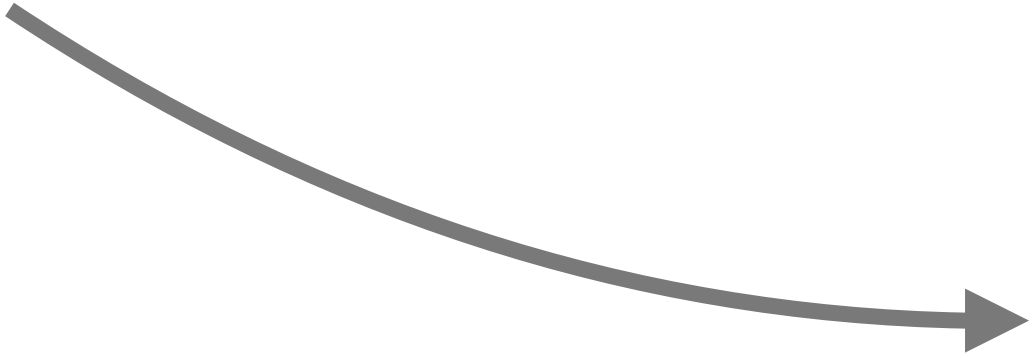


Proportionality:

justice prohibits very unequal treatment of persons who are very similar in their relevant properties.

No one in group A
is very similar in
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anyone in group B.



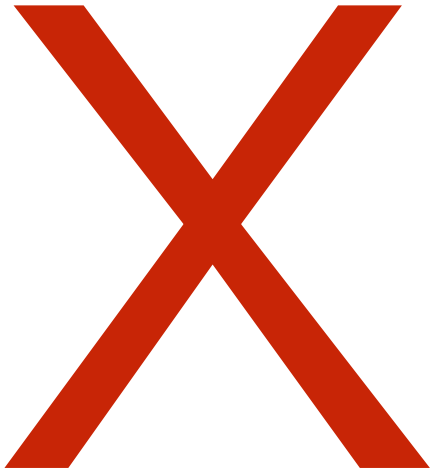




Continuity: There is no way of dividing all people into two groups so that no one in one group is similar in their relevant properties to anyone in the other group.

Justice:

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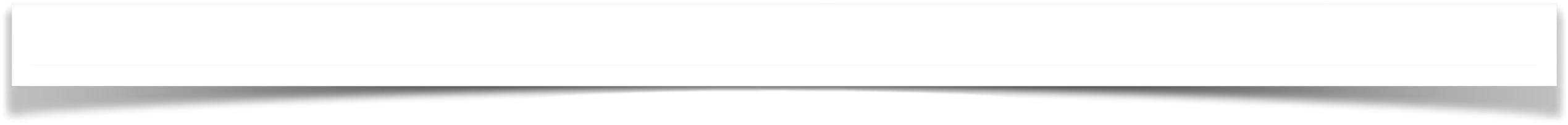
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A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "evil & lives not worth living" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

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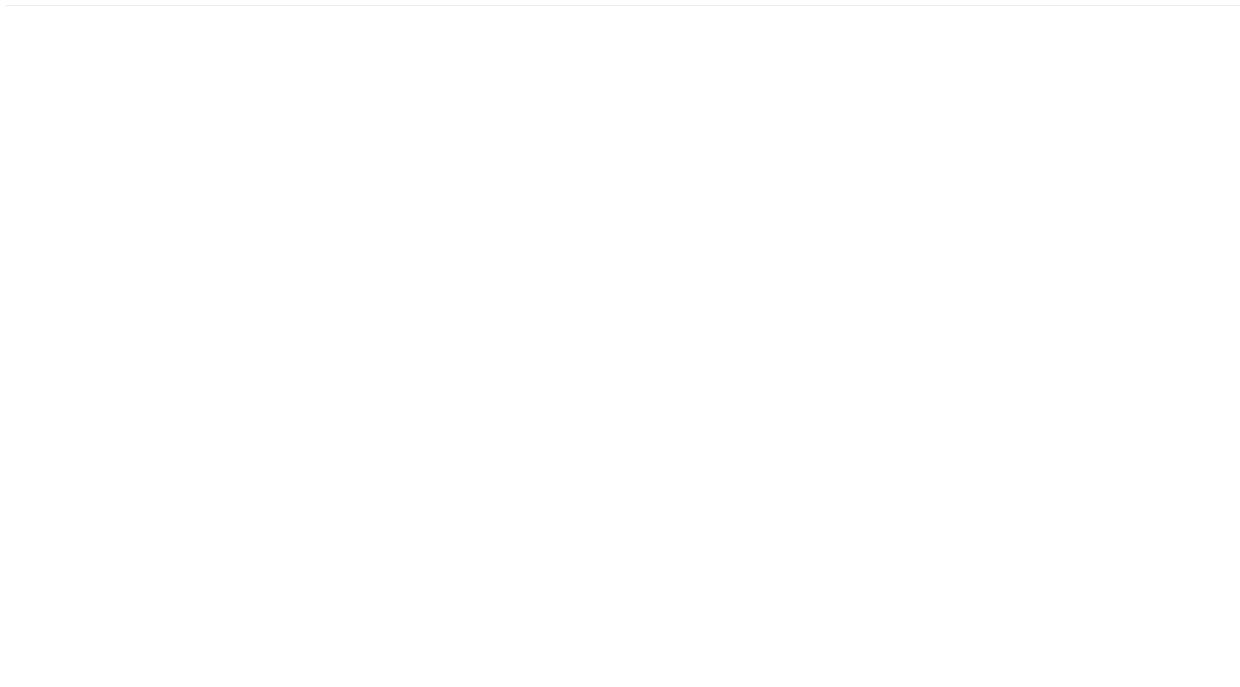
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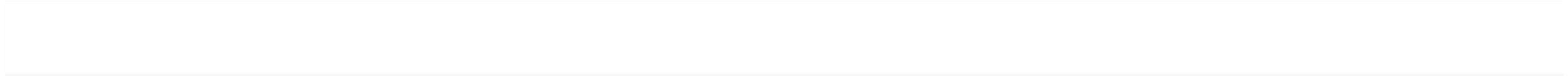
















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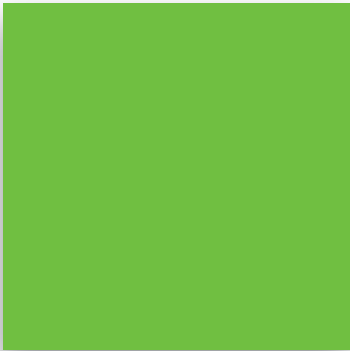
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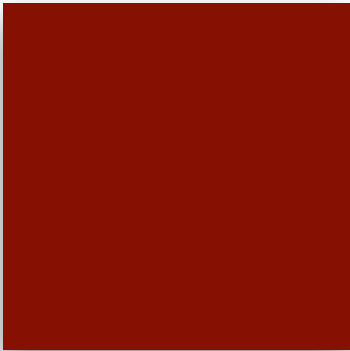
















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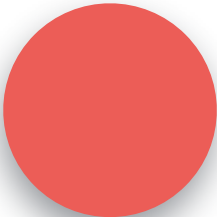
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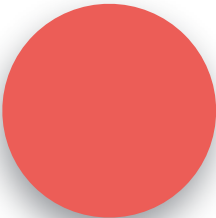
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